and that domestic abuse, penalising and female-bashing must remain as cogent and real indicators as the glass ceiling in the matter of gender attitudes.

If gender equality and the struggle for it by women in its earliest historical formulation meant suffrage and the sanction to vote, more than a century later, the inability to do so of one's own accord and as a free-thinking individual certainly doesn't vindicate the rights of women. The notion that intellectual judgement or rational choices by adult women might still depend on male affirmation in the family challenges ideas and notions about India's gender equality. Nearly half of the population across the heteronormative genders and along the rural-urban segments in India profess that males are better equipped to decide domestic matters, volunteering away opportunities for women to be actually independent and empowered. A quarter of the respondents decidedly say no, but what is significant is that more states in the south of the country, with Kerala leading the count, "strongly disagree" on the matter. Does matriliny or matriarchal societies or perhaps literate populations balance the gender equation? Without an index from the north-eastern states except Assam, which is part of the survey, this is difficult to tell. And even if the NE cluster was to be included, is there proof that it is more gender-equal? Lack of electoral representation and real political participation in many of the states disinvest women of equality and equity in the region that has ironically had the privilege of some of the country's first Mahila Samitis, the Nupi Lan, or even the trailblazing Naga Mothers' Association.



Are we, then, still far from being a gender-equal nation or people? Where women's incomes have risen and they are often well-educated and attain positions of leadership, yet the gender norm prevails over basic questions like who decides, who works, who has greater liberties and who will a girl marry? Research in the social sciences and humanities has revealed that women exhibit greater communal behaviour and work well in solidarities and with groups while men are agentic and often lead the herd or dominate the group. In addition to this, traditional gender roles (read 'feminine') and socialisation patterns seem to influence the way men and women behave in social and domestic spheres and are also corroborated by perceptions that grow and persist out of this scenario.

Thus, findings around the question of women's freedom to marry of their own choice and in defiance of parents' will indicate a shared response across the rural-urban segments with about half of the respondents vehemently disagreeing with such freedom. On the other hand, over half the respondents across the gender split agree that women should be allowed to work away from their homes while over 77 per cent across rural-urban segments believe that daughters should pursue as good an education as boys do, even as a number of states reveal regressive attitudes. Evidently, gender stereotypes create a double bind for women whose competence, qualification or potential agency are blunted in order that they conform to the patriarchal stronghold. Financial autonomy and economic independence, while guaranteeing the place of the single woman in our society, is an issue that elicits mixed responses and there is no overwhelming majority about a woman's claim to her own money. Virginia Woolf's famous feminist position about "a room of one's own (and money)" and her passionate exhortation to women of her world to "possess yourselves of money to travel and to idle..." seems sadly a wishful thought as far as domestic behaviour in our country goes. If there is a passport, women don't necessarily travel here.

The notion that intellectual judgement by adult women might still depend on male affirmation challenges notions about India's gender equality

Yet, I am hopeful that a younger India is likely to be more gender-equal, more democratic as it loosens away from centuries of entrenched and embedded patriarchies. The woman shall walk alone and rise, and still she must rise. ■

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